

3.5 Language and Regional Variation (Paper 3 pathway)

Edexcel A-Level English Language (9EN0) — Paper 3 Investigating Language

The Regional Variation pathway investigates UK dialect diversity: its distinctive features, the classic sociolinguistic studies (Labov, Trudgill, Milroy, Cheshire, Petyt), and the forces shaping it (dialect levelling, MLE, covert prestige). A Paper 3 answer must integrate named studies with close reading of unseen regional-speech data.

3.5.1 UK Regional Varieties — Distinctive Features

Variety	Key features
Cockney	H-dropping ("ouse"); t-glottalisation ("be'er"); th-fronting ("fink"); double negation; rhyming slang
Estuary English	Middle ground between RP and Cockney — spreading SE England
Geordie (Tyneside)	Distinctive vowels; "pet", "howay", "bairn", "nowt"
Scouse (Liverpool)	Velar fricatives; affrication of /t/ and /k/; "made up" = pleased
Yorkshire	Short /a/ in "bath"; definite-article reduction ("t' pub"); "owt/nowt"
West Country	Rhotic /r/ after vowels; rural "thee/thou"
Welsh English	Sing-song intonation; invariant tag "isn't it"; Welsh-origin lexis
Scottish English / Scots	Rolled /r/; "wee", "bairn", "dreich"; distinctive modal use

MLE (Multicultural London English)

Fronted GOOSE; "man" as indefinite pronoun; lexis from Caribbean/SA sources

3.5.2 The Classic Sociolinguistic Studies

Labov — New York Department Stores (1966)

Labov elicited post-vocalic /r/ in "fourth floor" across three stores of different social prestige (Saks — high, Macy's — mid, S. Klein — low) in casual and careful speech. Found /r/ increased with store prestige AND speech formality. Lower-middle-class Macy's staff hypercorrected — producing more /r/ than upper-middle-class Saks staff in careful speech. Established systematic correlation between linguistic variables and social variables.

Labov — Martha's Vineyard (1963)

Centralisation of diphthongs linked to IDENTITY — islanders distancing themselves from mainland summer visitors.

Trudgill — Norwich (1974)

Five social classes; variables including /ing/. Findings:

- Standard forms increased with class + formality.
- Women used more standard forms than men of the same class.
- Men over-reported non-standard use — covert prestige.
- Women over-reported standard use — overt prestige.

Milroy — Belfast (1980)

Measured network density (interconnectedness) and multiplexity (roles per contact). High-density networks correlated with more local vernacular. Shifted attention from class categories to social networks.

Cheshire — Reading (1982)

Adolescent peer groups. Non-standard grammatical features (e.g. "we was", multiple negation) correlated with tough peer-group membership — covert prestige through peer norms.

Petyt — Bradford

H-dropping correlated with social class — confirmed in a second urban context.

Kerswill — Dialect Levelling

Paul Kerswill shows mobility, media and education are reducing distinctive local features in UK English, producing more regionally levelled varieties. However new urban varieties (MLE) emerge too.

3.5.3 Prestige — Overt and Covert

- **Overt prestige** — prestige attached to publicly valued standard forms (e.g. RP for a newsreader).
- **Covert prestige** — hidden prestige attached to non-standard forms within a group (e.g. a teenager using MLE to mark peer identity).

Both forces act on every speaker. Most speakers style-shift fluidly between them.

3.5.4 Accommodation Theory — Giles

- **Convergence** — moving speech style *towards* the listener, to build rapport or manage social distance.
- **Divergence** — moving speech style *away* from the listener, often to assert identity or power.
- **Maintenance** — keeping one's own style.

3.5.5 Social Class and Language

- **Class-stratified variation** — H-dropping, t-glottalisation, double negation correlate with class.
- **Hypercorrection** — aspirant groups overshooting the prestige norm (Labov).

- **Bernstein's restricted / elaborated codes** — controversial for implying working-class speech is deficient. Labov's work on AAVE shows vernacular varieties are rule-governed. Modern linguistics prefers "code difference" to "code deficit".

3.5.6 Age, Gender and Other Variables

- **Age** — younger speakers often lead sound change.
- **Gender** — Trudgill found women use more standard forms than men of the same class in formal contexts.
- **Style-shifting** — the same speaker adjusting register across contexts.
- **Idiolect** — every speaker is individual; within-group variation is huge.

3.5.7 Community of Practice — Eckert & McConnell-Ginet

A group cohering around shared practices and goals. Members develop shared repertoires including linguistic ones. Allows intersectional analysis: speakers belong to multiple communities, each contributing to their idiolect. Moves beyond static class/gender categories.

3.5.8 Case Study: MLE

Multicultural London English (MLE) emerged in late-20th / early-21st century London through dense multiethnic peer networks. Researched by **Cheshire and Kerswill**. Key features:

- Vowels: fronted GOOSE, distinctive FACE and GOAT.
- Lexis: "ting", "mandem", "wasteman" from Caribbean / South Asian / vernacular London sources.
- Grammar: "man" as indefinite pronoun ("man's tired"); new quotatives "this is me...".
- Features shared across ethnic lines — a community-of-practice variety, not tied to one ethnicity.

Media representations ("jafaican", "street slang") frame MLE pejoratively — standard-language ideology treating rule-governed innovation as threat.

Applied Example: A transcript of a West-London builder: "Yeah nah we was down the yard an' me mate goes 'ain't liftin' that mate' an' I'm like bruv." Features: non-standard preterite "we was" (vernacular), "me" as possessive (London), "ain't" (covert prestige), quotative "I'm like" (MLE/youth), address "mate", "bruv" (peer solidarity). Apply Trudgill on covert prestige, Milroy on network density. Avoid deficit framing: the variety is rule-governed and indexes working-class London + MLE identity.

3.5.9 Attitudes to Regional Varieties

UK regional varieties have historically faced stigmatisation. Cockney, Geordie, MLE and AAVE have all been represented negatively in media at different times. Top-band Paper 3 answers acknowledge this and explain why the stigma is linguistically unfounded (all rule-governed varieties are legitimate) while recognising its social force.

3.5.10 How to Analyse Regional Variation

1. Identify the **variety**: which region, class, age, ethnicity, community?
2. Identify **specific features**: phonology (H-dropping, t-glottalisation), lexis, grammar, prosody.
3. Link to **named studies**: Labov, Trudgill, Milroy, Cheshire, Petyt, Kerswill.
4. Apply **concepts**: overt/covert prestige, accommodation, network density, community of practice.
5. Engage with **attitudes**: how is the variety perceived? What ideology does this encode?
6. Evaluate: acknowledge rule-governed nature; avoid deficit framing.

Paper 3 Tip: Edexcel Paper 3 rewards precise reference to at least two named studies. Don't just say "sociolinguistics shows..." — say "Trudgill's 1974 Norwich study showed... which supports...". Always link features to meaning, identity or social context. Top-band answers integrate identity, prestige, network AND attitudes.

Key Terms Checklist

Accent, dialect, idiolect, sociolect, Standard English, RP, overt / covert prestige, hypercorrection, accommodation (convergence / divergence / maintenance), network density, community of practice, levelling, restricted / elaborated code, anti-language, pidgin, creole, lectal continuum, MLE. Studies: Labov (NY + Martha's Vineyard), Trudgill (Norwich), Milroy (Belfast), Cheshire (Reading), Petyt (Bradford), Kerswill (Milton Keynes + MLE).